Metered lines in prose: an experimental study on Russian

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Prosaic texts sometimes contain metered fragments. Literary scholars view them as a stylistic device when studying fiction (for Russian, see e.g. Orlickij, 2002; Orekhov, 2022). However, it has not been explored so far whether ordinary readers react to them in any way, consciously or unconsciously. To address this question, we used a variety of **methods**, focusing at different aspects and different levels of the readers' perception of metered and unmetered fragments:

- measuring reading times (task **A**);
- estimating how much the readers liked the fragment in two tasks, focusing the readers' attention on the relevant properties of the fragment (**B2**) or not (**B1**);
- asking the readers to guess what the difference between the two types of fragments is (**C**);
- asking the readers to classify metered / unmetered fragments after an explicit instruction (**D**).

Although nobody studied metered fragments in prose experimentally, several **hypotheses** can be made based on other relevant studies (but only for the tasks A and B1/2):

- *Hypothesis 1A on reading times (task A).* In the literary studies, using metered prose is viewed as an instance of foregrounding (using different linguistic devices to make certain words or text fragments to stand out and thus drawing the reader's attention to them). Other foregrounding devices are known to slow the readers down (e.g. Miall, Kuiken, 1994; Hakemulder, 2004), so if using metered prose is indeed one of them, we can expect the same.
- *Hypothesis 1B on reading times (task A).* At the same time, we know that metered poetry is read faster than unmetered poetry (Menninghaus, Wallot, 2020).
- *Hypothesis 2 on esthetic ratings (task B1/2).* Metered lines in poetry receive higher esthetic ratings than unmetered ones (van Peer, 1986; Menninghaus, Wallot, 2020).

Our **materials** were 30 fragments from the Russian prose of the 19th century. In every fragment, there was a metered part (stimulus) that coincided with a complete clause and was 6-8 feet long (to make it salient enough) and a short context on the left (see (1a)). We had 16 fragments with two-syllabic meters and 14 with three-syllabic ones. For every fragment, we created an unmetered control version introducing minor changes in the word order or auxiliary words (see (1b)).

The study had the following **design**. In its first part, our **participants** (N=60) read the fragments in the SPR mode: first the stimulus (in the control or experimental condition), then the context, while reading times were measured (*task A*). After every fragment, the readers were asked to estimate how good it sounds on the 1 to 5 scale (*task B1*). Then the participants were divided in two groups for the 'more conscious' tasks. The first group was told that we introduced *some* changes into half of the fragments they had just read. Then the participants saw 14 pairs of fragments (in both conditions, one above the other in a random order, one pair at a time) and were asked to select which one sounds better (*task B2*). After that, the participants were asked to guess what the difference between the fragments in these pairs actually was (*task C*). The second group of participants was told explicitly that some fragments they had read contained metered parts, with a detailed explanation and several examples (not from our stimulus set). Then they saw the fragments from the first part one by one and were asked to answer whether they contained metered parts or not (*task D*). The whole study was conducted online on the IbexFarm platform.

Results and discussion. In the *task A*, metered fragments were read significantly faster, supporting the Hypothesis 1B (see Fig. 1). Metered fragments received higher esthetic ratings both in the *task B1* (see Fig. 2) and in the *task B2*, supporting the Hypothesis 2. However, as Fig. 2 and a more detailed analysis show, this effect was driven by two-syllable meters. Apparently, three-syllable meters are more difficult to detect for a Russian reader, which is an interesting result

requiring further research. At the same time, we received *no* correct responses in the *task C* and the average accuracy was as low as 52% in the *task D*. We can conclude that the readers react to metered prose (both in terms of reading times and esthetically), but do not discern metered fragments consciously, even when being explicitly instructed.

Examples

(1) a. Experimental:
Stimulus: *Ži'l on skro'mno, smi'rno, ti'xo, na'm ego' ne sly'šno by'lo* (trochaic, 7 feet).
Context: *Zdorov'e ne pozvoljalo emu xodit' postojanno v universitet.*

b. Control:
Stimulus: *On žil skromno, smirno i tixo, nam bylo ego ne slyšno.*
Translation: 'He lived modestly, quietly (and) peacefully; we never heard from him. His health did not allow him to attend university regularly.'
Source: *Poor People* (Dostoevsky).

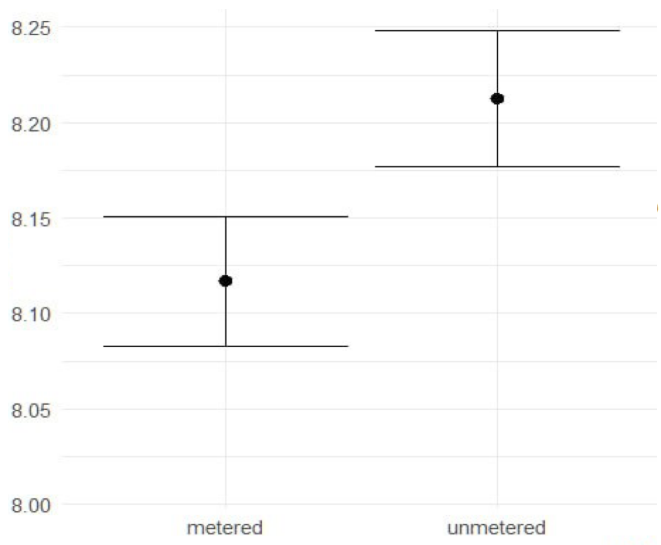

Fig. 1. Average RTs in the task A (in log ms).

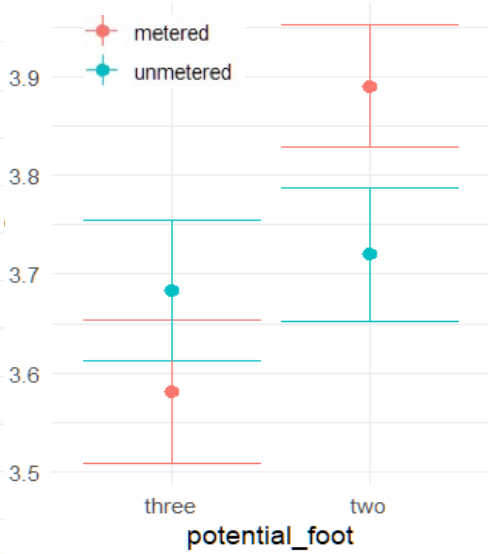

Fig. 2. Average ratings in the task B1.

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